Sensory Series: Touch

In short

For some neurodivergent people, things touching their skin feel much stronger than usual. Labels, rough fabric, or cold desks can be distressing. Letting people choose comfortable clothes, and respecting personal space, helps.

Overview

Think about how many things touch your skin during a standard workday. For a neurodivergent person with sensitivity to touch, the physical world can feel much stronger than it does for other people. The brain often can't mute these physical inputs, which turns minor textures into a source of constant distress.

It's not just about a scratchy clothing label or a stiff uniform, though those can easily spoil a whole afternoon of focus. The office environment itself can present unexpected problems. A freezing metal desk, a rough chair fabric, or a sudden breeze from the air conditioning can feel deeply unsettling. Physical boundaries matter a lot too, since an unexpected tap on the shoulder can easily startle someone's entire nervous system.

Creating a physically comfortable workspace allows everyone to put their energy into their actual jobs instead of just coping with discomfort.

Giving people control over their immediate environment is a brilliant first step. This might mean allowing casual, soft clothing or letting staff use their own desk mats and chair covers. Respecting personal space by avoiding uninvited physical contact is another simple way to help colleagues feel secure.

Useful links

- Autism and sensory processing
- Autism Understood: sensitivity to touch
- Humber NHS sensory processing hub: touch

Abbreviations

The full form of each abbreviation used in this document.

NHS: National Health Service